

ENGLISH, POWER, ACCESS

Printing, Rules, Status

WHO SET THE STANDARD?

04 / 12



English varied before print

SPELLING

Many forms

Scribes made choices.

DIALECT

Local words

Regions sounded different.

CONTROL

No single ruler

Change stayed gradual.

Variation was normal.

Caxton's press repeated choices

1476

Press opened

Westminster became central.

CHOICE

Printers selected

Spellings became reusable.

REACH

Copies multiplied

Chosen forms travelled.

Printing accelerated selection.

Egges or eyren?

NORTHERN FORM

egges

One shopper spoke.

SOUTHERN FORM

eyren

One seller understood.

Caxton recorded this around 1490.

A standard remained unsettled.

Dictionaries ranked choices

JOHNSON

1755

Two printed
volumes.

Selected spellings

Choices gained authority.

Quoted writers

Literature became evidence.

Admitted change

English stayed alive.

Dictionaries record human choices.

Schools spread written norms

1870

1880

LATER



School
boards

Attendance
rules

Shared
lessons

More children met standards.

Schooling widened their reach.

Standard gained social power

POWER EFFECTS

Schools rewarded conformity.

Editors copied common forms.

Employers judged voices.

LINGUISTIC LIMITS

Dialect rules still exist.

Regional speech remains meaningful.

Prestige does not prove quality.

Standard never meant superior.

Sources and limits

Caxton collections

Printing and variation

Johnson, 1755

Dictionary preface

Education Acts

1870 and 1880

Accent research

Hierarchy persists

EVIDENCE

INFERENCE

UNPROVEN

NEXT: Empire and English